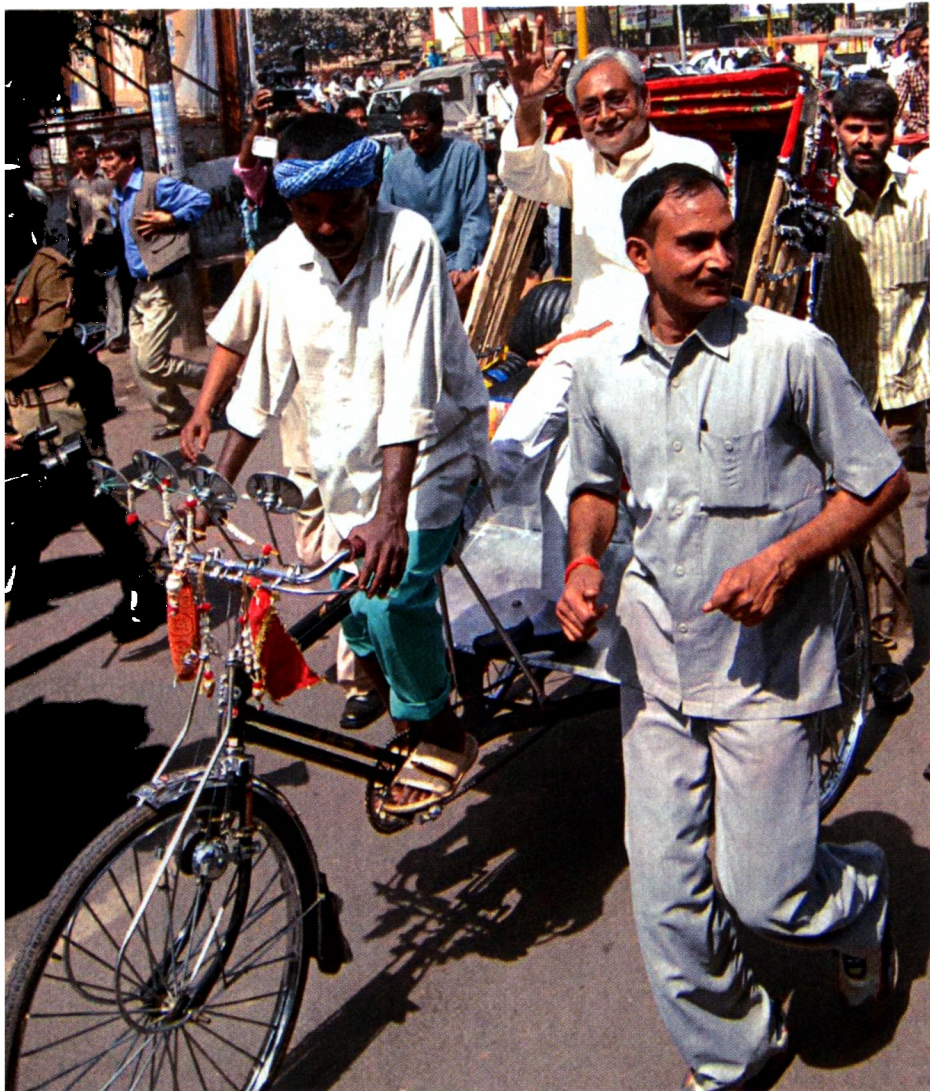


KRISHNA MURARI KISHAN



Survival of the Fittest

Nitish's journey from a student leader to becoming chief minister

1974: Led the Student Movement under Jayaprakash Narayan while at the Bihar College of Engineering.

1977, 1980: Lost assembly elections while contemporaries Paswan and Lalu entered the Lok Sabha in 1977.

1985: Elected from Harnaut.

1989: Elected to the Lok Sabha after defeating Congress heavyweight Ramlakhan Singh Yadav.

1994: Split with Lalu. Samata Party formed with George Fernandes and 12 others, but could send only six MLAs to the assembly a year later.

1998: Became railway minister when the NDA came to power.

March 2000: Bihar chief minister for 7 days, couldn't prove majority.

December 2003: Instrumental in Samata Party-JD(U) merger.

May 2005: Assembly dissolved when about to cobble up a majority.

November 2005: Became Bihar chief minister with a clear majority.

tal, Nitish has to subordinate everything to his twin agenda to win a second term. Anything else, no matter how popular or deserving like his Janata Darbar, has had to give way if it interfered with the top priority. Perhaps therefore, the Bihar chief minister, who is a member of the Legislative Council, by all indications, will not contest elections himself.

To an outsider, it may appear not in sync with Bihar's personality driven politics—or with Nitish's man-of-the-masses image. But, in this election year, Nitish's calculations dovetail perfectly with his twin jobs of strategising and spearheading campaigns without having the compulsions of being unduly worried about one partic-

NITISH BORROWS A LEAF FROM LALU'S POPULIST STYLEBOOK TO ENDEAR HIMSELF TO VOTERS

ular seat. History supports his monofocus on campaigning rather than contesting elections. Last year, the Lok Sabha elections were the first time in 20 years when Nitish did not personally contest the parliamentary polls. But he was singlehandedly responsible for the NDA walking away with 32 of the 40 Lok Sabha seats in the state. Nitish, however, has not been graceful in defeat. Last year in September, when the NDA lost 13 of the 18 assembly seats that went to polls, he described it as "just a (inconsequential) practice match" and

blamed almost everyone, including the voters, while suggesting they failed to foresee the negatives of letting Lalu and Paswan staging a comeback in Bihar. There was a definite invocation of fear in his analysis.

Nitish has a clear advantage over Lalu, since he has delivered a much better government. In fact, when it comes to social engineering he seems to have done everything that Lalu has done; and a little extra too, although with a remarkably refined approach. But there are troubles as well. The BJP is uncomfortable with his pro-minority approach. But Nitish looks assured. The engineer in him perhaps knows that things always get worse before they get better. ■